

THE PORT OF CALL

The world's most prestigious yacht ocean race is coming to India for the first time and Kochi is leaving no stone unturned to make a successful debut

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

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This could be the biggest bonanza for God's own country. For Kochi has been selected as the only stop-over port in South Asia for the famed Volvo Ocean Race, world's fastest ocean yacht racing event which is held every four years. Kochi is among the 11 ports of call across the world where the 10 high-speed yachts would stop over for 10 days during the six-month-long sailing marathon which begins from Alicante in Spain on October 4, 2008, and ends at St Petersburg in Russia on June 9, 2009. The stopover at Kochi will be from December 3 to 13. It is for the first time in the 35-year-long history of the ocean adventure race (originally called Whitbread race) that Asia has been included in the itinerary. China's Qingdao is the only other Asian port where the race will stop over. "India and China are high on their agenda as they are the two most happening countries and emerging markets," says N. Ramachandran, chairman, Cochin Port Trust (CPT) which hosts the race at the Kochi port jointly with the Kerala Government's Tourism Department. "Kochi was picked despite major bids by many much larger

and high profile ports like Dubai and Singapore," he says.

Kochi has hit another jackpot too as the race organisers have waived the €10 million (Rs 60 crore) licence fee to be paid by each of the ports where the race stops over. "When we came to know about the fees we were reluctant and said would not be able to pay. But the organisers, after many visits to inspect the destination, decided to give us the waiver," says Ramachandran. However, CPT and the state tourism have launched a Rs 30-crore project to build a race village, a flotilla of 100 Kerala-style houseboats to house the



CRUISE ARRIVALS IN INDIA

PORT	2004-05	2005-06	2006-07	2007-08
KOCHI	19	22	38	43
MUMBAI	16	18	31	26
MORMUGAO	11	10	32	31
MANGALORE	8	3	18	17

FLOATING GLORY: A scene of the last Volvo Ocean race; Queen Victoria at Cochin Port (left)

guests, spruce up the port's facilities, extend berthing facilities, construct new multi-storey office building for the race, a 60,000-sq meter covered exhibition plaza and upgrade roads, bridges etc to rise up to the international event.

The event, which attracts global media attention, is also seen as a unique business opportunity for many high-profile global corporate houses and major brands that sponsor the 10-odd yachts and gather at the ports to cheer their respective teams. The opportunity has also come to

"Kochi will be an unforgettable experience for the Volvo race."
KODIYERI BALAKRISHNAN, TOURISM MINISTER, KERALA